

SHUTTERSTOCK

Ernest Hemingway's imprint is all over Havana, Cuba. There are the bars where the Noble laureate treated himself to daiquiris and mojitos. It's also where he wrote two of his classics, *The Old Man and the Sea* and *For Whom the Bell Tolls*, crediting the privacy the country offered him for his creative spurt. No wonder he dedicated the Nobel Prize to the Caribbean island. Among the denizens he was endearingly referred to as 'Papa'.

In the aftermath of the revolution and the rise of Fidel Castro, the American would leave Cuba for good in 1960. A few months later he'd die by suicide.

Bar hopping

It's by far the most touristy spot in Havana, but then it's hard to ignore Floridita, which brands itself as the birthplace of daiquiri (There's one named after Hemingway too). Walk in any evening and you're likely to run into the band who perform in a small space adjacent to the door. It's got a sky-blue ceiling, bright red tables and photos of Hemingway adorning its walls, but the main attraction is a life-size bronze statue of the man himself. Get a daiquiri and imitate the author in all earnestness –elbow leaning on table and one hand on the waist.

Next head to La Bodeguita del Medio where getting a table is near impossible but a mojito is certainly possible. That's because the bartender puts on quite a show making it—by lining up 30 to 40 glasses so that when tourists come in, they get their fill as well as a photograph for the 'gram. Of the umpteen signatures that are scribbled all over the walls, there's one supposedly of Hemingway too with the statement: "My mojito in La Bodeguita, my daiquiri in El Floridita". For its chatter and infectious energy which spreads to the Empedrado street, Bodeguita is worth a visit.

TIP: At the Almacenes San Jose Artisans' Market, you can purchase many souvenirs relating to the popular bars such as tote bags and fridge magnets.

Finca Vigia

Located 45 minutes away from central Havana in the lively San Francisco de Paula neighbourhood is Hemingway's not-so-humble abode, a space which offers ample proof as to why the author made it his home for nearly two decades. It houses a pool which hosted many Hollywood stars in the 1940-50s; a cemetery to his four dogs; a cockfighting ring; a small patch where he is said to have played baseball and even started a youth team called Gigi's Stars; a three-storey structure called the tower and his beloved fishing boat, *Pilar*. It's on this boat that he made trips with his friend Gregorio Fuentes who is said to be the inspiration for the fisherman in *The Old Man and the Sea*.

The pool's changing room has black-and-white family photographs featuring a beaming and relaxed Hemingway. While entry into the house is not allowed, walk around and peer into the windows and doors to get a view of the study which still holds his many books (numbering 4,000 at least) and writing desk. Don't miss out the bathroom where you will see a weighing scale and a wall with scribbles, where the writer was keeping track of his weight.

TIP: Climb atop the Tower to get a scenic view of the city.

Hotel Ambos Mundos

Before he found refuge at Finca Vigia, Hemingway was a permanent guest at Ambos Mundos hotel located on the buzzing Obispo Street. His preferred room No. 511 during his stay here from 1932-39 is currently preserved as a small museum and holds several of his belongings including a Remington typewriter. Currently painted in salmon pink, Ambos Mundos also has a roof flower garden which it boasts has the "most beautiful view of Havana".



ALAMY

Liquid Lunches

(clockwise from top left) Hemingway at Finca Vigia; La Bodeguita del Medio; and interior and exterior of Floridita